This apparent obsession with the safety of India was not without justification. In 1801 for example, Tsar Paul I looked to take advantage of Britain's troubles with France by proposing to Napoleon a joint endeavour against India.[72] While Paul I's plans failed to come to fruition, the temptation to try to unbalance British rule in India always remained.[73] And despite later repeated assurances from St Petersburg that it had no hostile intentions towards India, the pace of Russia's expansion into Asia in the nineteenth century was dramatic enough to be of concern to Britain. For four centuries the Russian empire had expanded at a rate of some fifty-five square miles a day, something of which British officials were only too aware. In 1836, Sir John McNeill, the newly appointed British minister to Persia, published a book detailing Russia's territorial gains in Europe and Asia from the time of Peter the Great.[74] Containing a folding map illustrating Russia's expansion over the last century, McNeill's book vividly warned of Russia's apparent inexorable march through the continent.[75] By the late 1800s, the Caucasus, the Trans-Caspian region and the khanates of Khokand, Bokhara and Khiva had all come under Russian hegemony.[76] Moreover, between 1880 and 1904 Russia was busily carrying out a programme of railway construction in Central Asia. At the beginning of the nineteenth century more than 2,000 miles separated Britain and Russia in Asia; by the start of the twentieth century this had shrunk to a few hundred miles.

To many contemporary observers, it must have seemed that the legend of Peter the Great's will was true: that from his death bed, the great Tsar had commanded his successors to pursue what he believed to be Russia's destiny – domination of the world through ascendancy over India and Constantinople.[77] Whatever the reality behind the legend, Curzon for one believed that 'Russia was as much compelled to go forward as the earth is to go around the sun'.[78] As for Russia's true intentions towards India, Curzon and de Lacy Evans were not wrong when they believed that their imperial rivals were too smart to contemplate a full-scale invasion of that country.

Nevertheless, the more astute Russian leaders realised that threatening the jewel in Britain's imperial crown was always a convenient way of gaining leverage in negotiations. Thus, Russia was just as much a player in the